

Music teachers' attitudes towards and beliefs about learning and teaching how to play an instrument in early childhood

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“The earlier children learn, the better”

Reframing preschool

- “Ready for school”
- More scrutiny, control & quality expectations

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Instrumental music education: same logic

- Start early: head start
- New commercialised “child-friendly” instruments
- Younger and younger

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- Start early: head start
- New commercialised “child-friendly” instruments
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No knowledge base

- Studies on iECME remain very scarce
- A scientific basis is almost non-existent
- Little scrutiny, control or quality expectation

AIM, THEORETICAL LENS & RESEARCH QUESTIONS

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Teachers' ***personal interpretative framework***: "the lens through which teachers look at their job, give meaning to it and act in it" (Kelchtermans, 2009).

Beliefs shape practice, so they are the place to start.

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RQ1 • Beliefs

What beliefs do music teachers and musicians hold about learning and teaching an instrument in the early years (ages 5–7)?

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RQ1 • Beliefs

What beliefs do music teachers and musicians hold about learning and teaching an instrument in the early years (ages 5–7)?

RQ2 • Predictors

Which background factors — demographic, personal, professional — predict those beliefs?

Three documented approaches to early instrumental learning

Suzuki

- Mother-tongue approach
- Rote & aural recall; sound before sight
- Repertoire-based, sequential
- Strong parental role (“Suzuki triangle”)

ColourStrings

- Kodály-based, whole-child
- Colour-coded notation from the start
- Individualised, playful
- Embedded in Finnish state schools

Pi Method

- By ear → notation; own pace
- Large-group music + small-group instrument
- Game-based imagery
- Improvisation throughout

Shared goal: a love of music and an engaged child.

They differ mainly in the balance of technique vs. creativity, and notation timing.

CHILD-FRIENDLY INSTRUMENTS

Scaled-down, affordable versions of traditional instruments are now widely marketed for young children — clarinet, saxophone, flute, bassoon, even brass (e.g. Nuvo, pBone, Fagonello).

> Marketed around readiness: a “head start”, getting children “ready to step up” to the “real” instrument.








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? No knowledge base

Although branded as play-based, how far do these programmes genuinely depart from teacher-centred, repertoire-first models — and how far do they simply reproduce them?








Method

Design, analysis & who responded

86 respondents - Snowball + purposeful sampling; teacher networks & associations

Ten languages - Online via LimeSurvey; translated & back-translated

5 Likert + 19 open items - Beliefs about 5–7 instrumental learning, plus background

Mixed analysis - Thematic analysis (Braun & Clarke) + non-parametric tests

Who responded

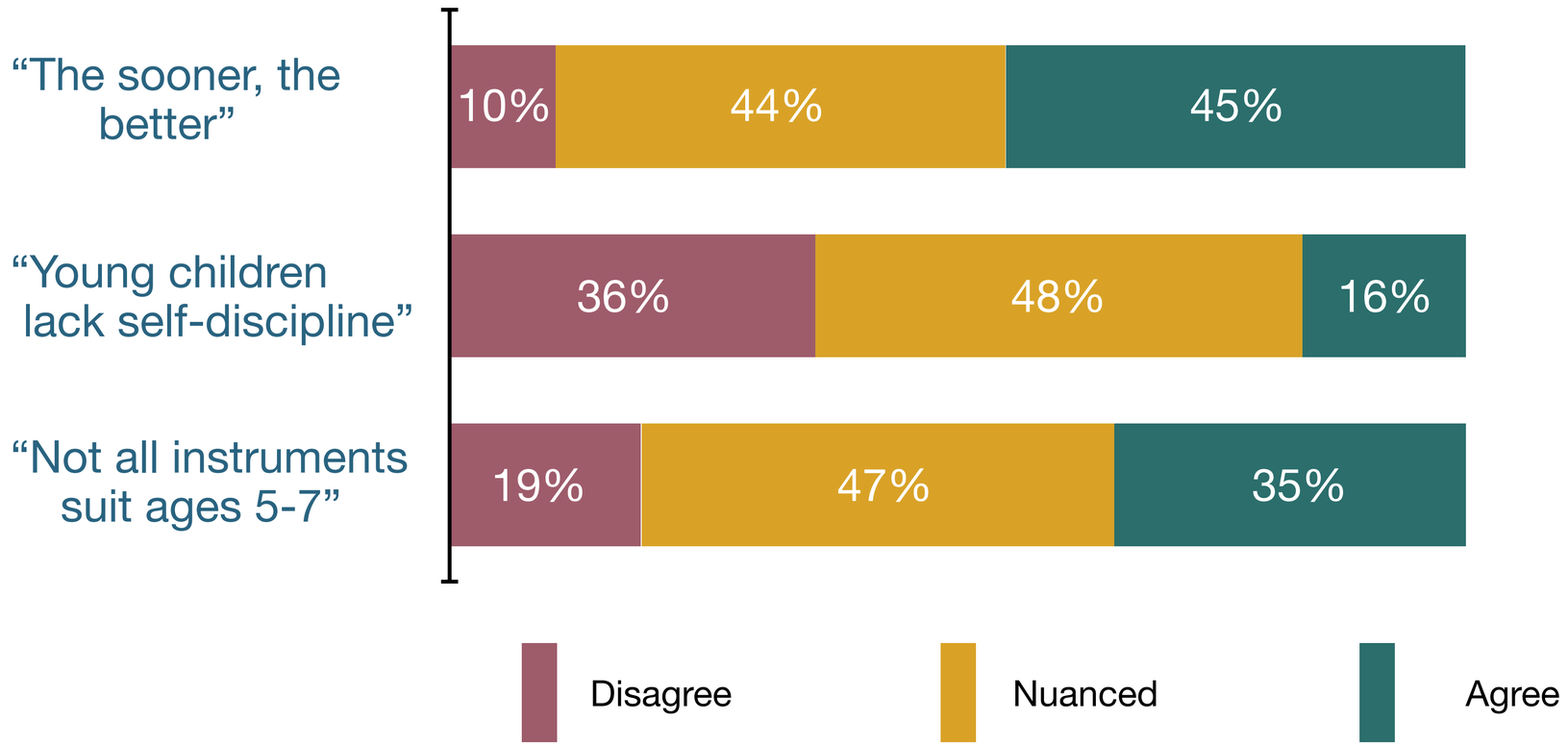
45 yrs
mean age

67%
female

21 yrs
mean teaching exp.

76%
hold an MA/PhD

Five belief items: agreement is rarely clear-cut



50% say children should build other skills first: motor, rhythm, listening, attention

72% favour neither individual nor group lessons but a combination of the two

“THE EARLIER THE MUSIC, THE BETTER” — NOT THE INSTRUMENT!

Across agreement levels, teachers redrew the question: what matters is early exposure to music, not early specialisation on a specific instrument. Many objected to the word “specific”, arguing children should explore before committing.

> *The earlier a child starts with MUSIC, the better.*

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What predicts agreement?

Teaching context, not musical biography.

Formal music-school teachers agreed more strongly (Mdn 6 vs 4, $p = .001$), as did those teaching 2–4-year-olds ($p = .005$).

Instrument, years playing, performance and genre — no association (all $p > .05$).

What might speak against an early start?

≈ 1 in 5

No objections

Even start earlier

Physical & physiological readiness

Small fingers, short arms … most instruments are designed for adults.” (304)

Volition & Motivation

“Coercion — if the desire … does not come from the child itself.” (140)

Pressure & loss of play

“With many obligations, there is no time left for free play.” (102)

Developmental readiness

“Unable to remain focused for a sufficient amount of time.” (78)

Dependence on adult/home support

“A young child needs the support of an adult to practice.” (243)

Teacher competence for the age

“Young children are regularly treated by music teachers as mini-adults.” (999)

Musicianship before the instrument

“It is necessary to first play with music, and only later to engage with it in a more serious, formal way.” (163)

Practical & individual barriers

“Parents are sometimes unable to offer their child this opportunity.” (266)

Patterns: wind & brass players cited physical limits far more (62% vs 32%, p = .042); bowed-string players — with smaller sizes available — least. Teaching the age group shifted the kind of objection, not its frequency.

WHY TEACHERS ARE IN FAVOUR OF AN EARLY START

Whole-child development — 62%

"Music is a transversal matter: mathematics, emotions, creativity, teamwork, fun." (166)

Developmental window — 51%

"The younger the child, the more malleable the brain, so learning comes more easily." (237)

Joy & Play — 40%

"Lots of joy, no exam pressure." (265)

Early investment (foundation) — 34%

"Become familiar with your instrument from childhood." (283)

The instrument as a vehicle

Value is placed beyond the notes & technique:

emotion, creativity, teamwork, transfer.

Joy is offered as the argument itself,

with an ethic against early performance pressure.

Broadly shared; no subgroup "owns" a theme

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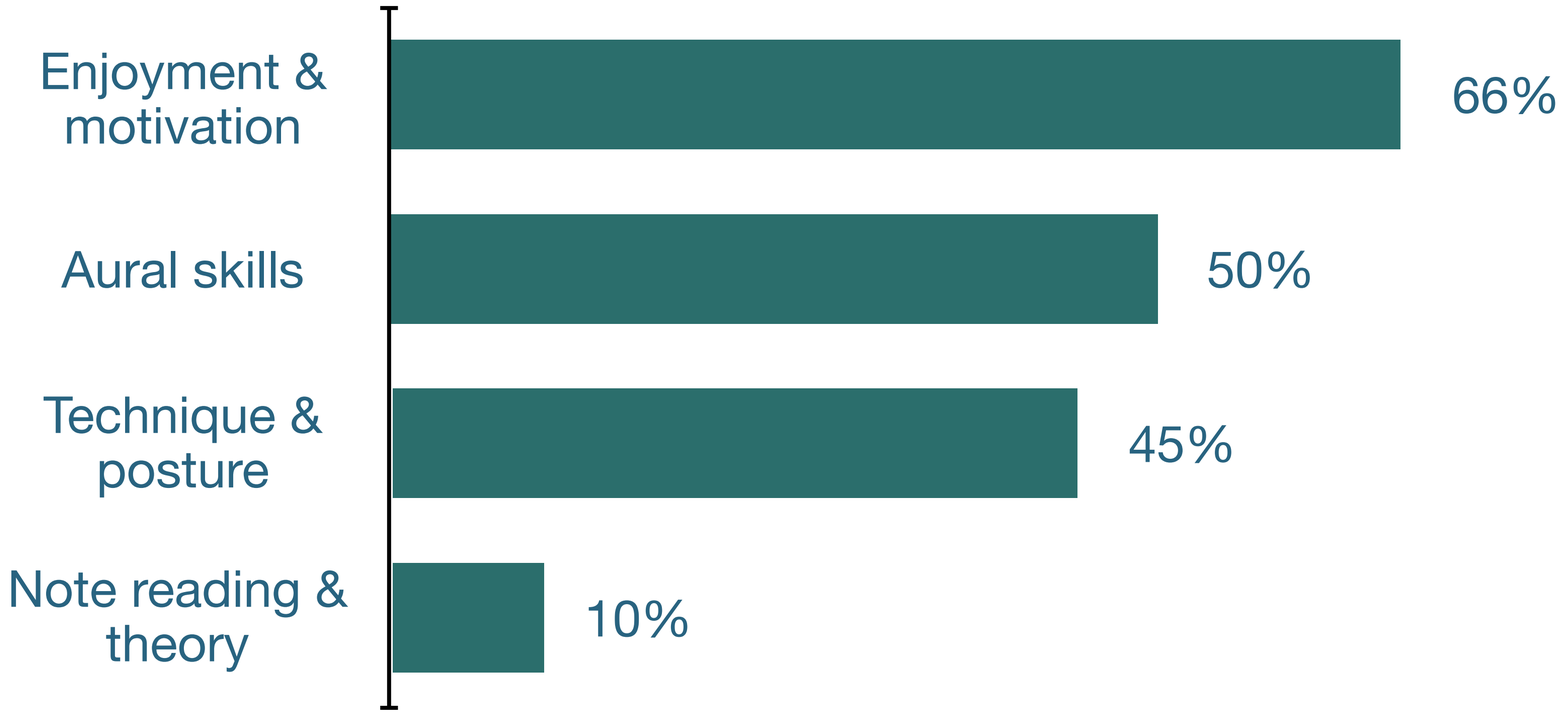
Some obervations on background (trend)

Teaching in higher education & more experience:

Less on foundations, more on joy & play

Private & music school: foundations

What to prioritise in a 5–7 lesson

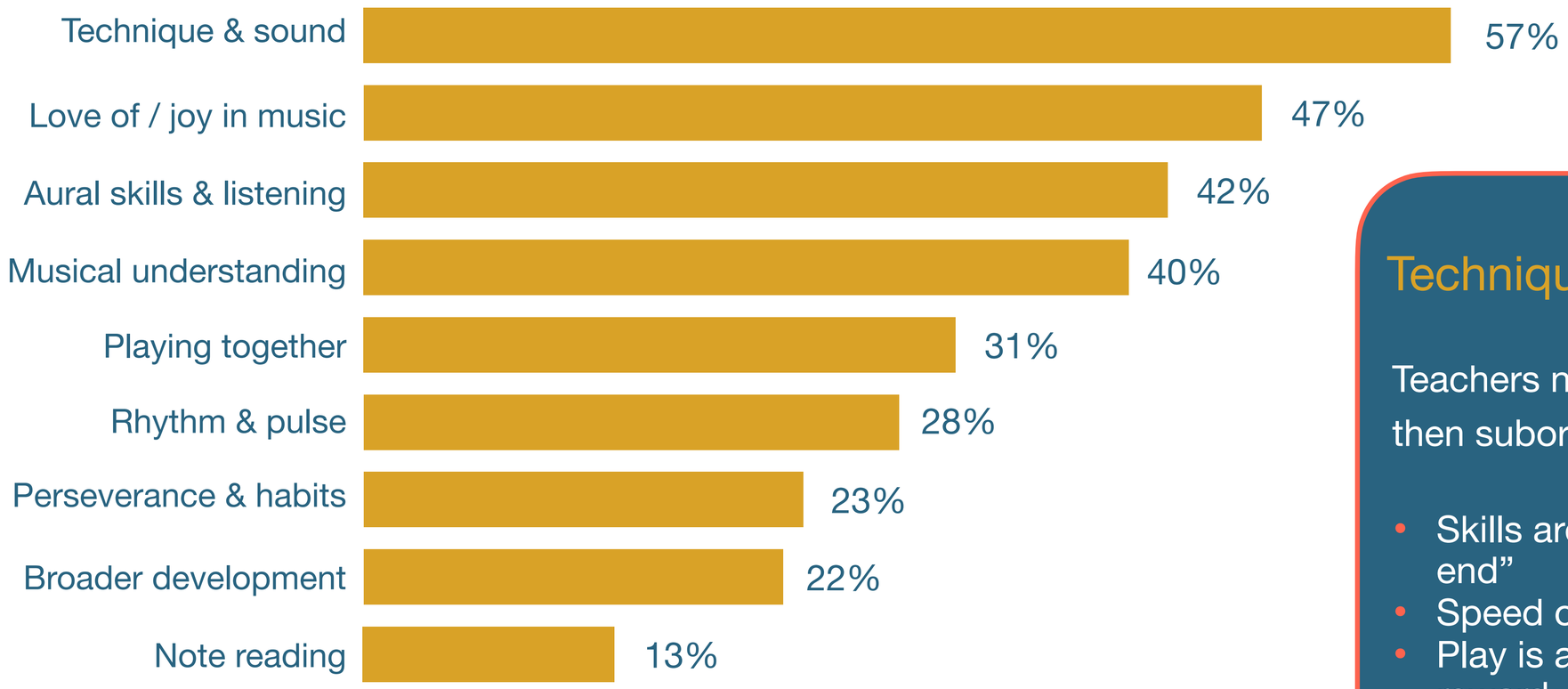


Instrument as vehicle

“The instrument is the means, not the end.” (70)

"*Reading notes is most often an impediment to making music*." (329)

THE MOST IMPORTANT LEARNING GOALS

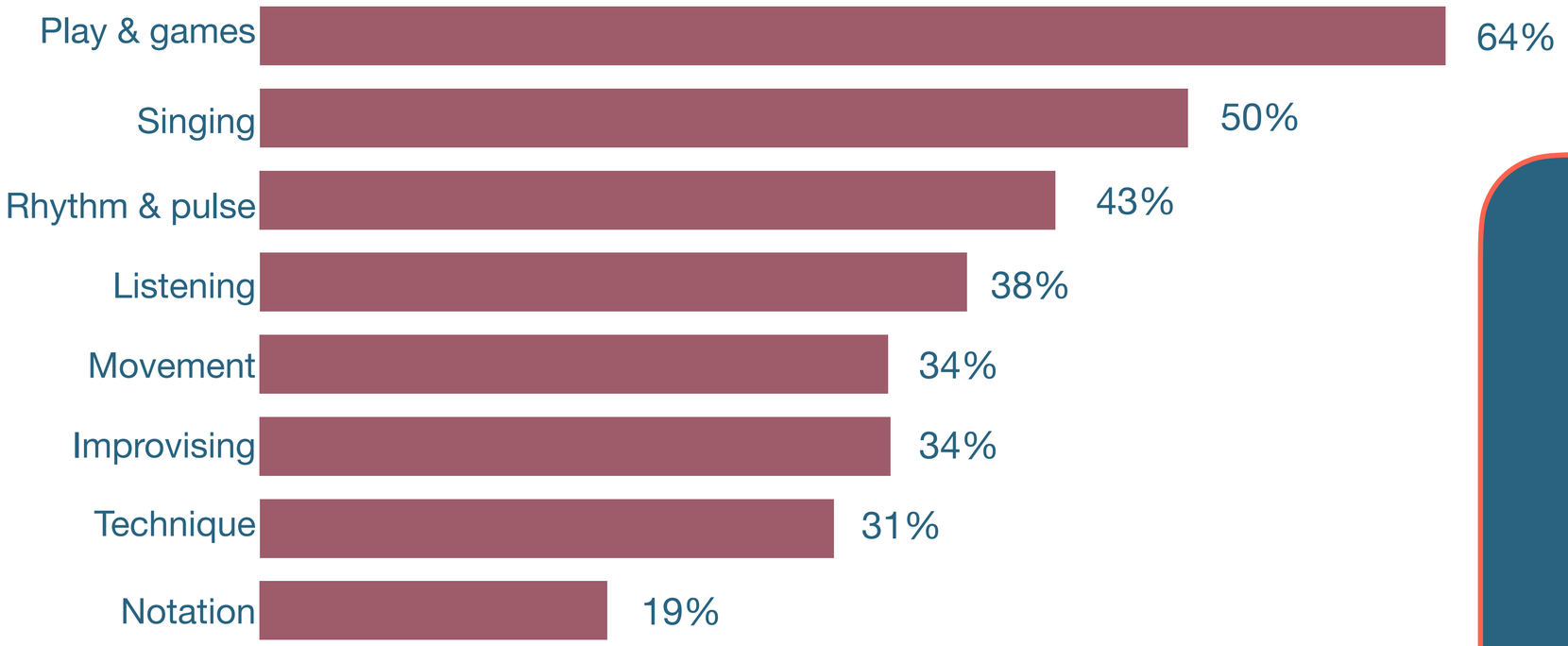


Technique in service of expression

Teachers name technique,
then subordinate it:

- Skills are “always a means to a musical end”
- Speed of progress is rejected
- Play is a condition of learning, not its reward

ESSENTIAL ACTIVITIES: A COHERENT PICTURE



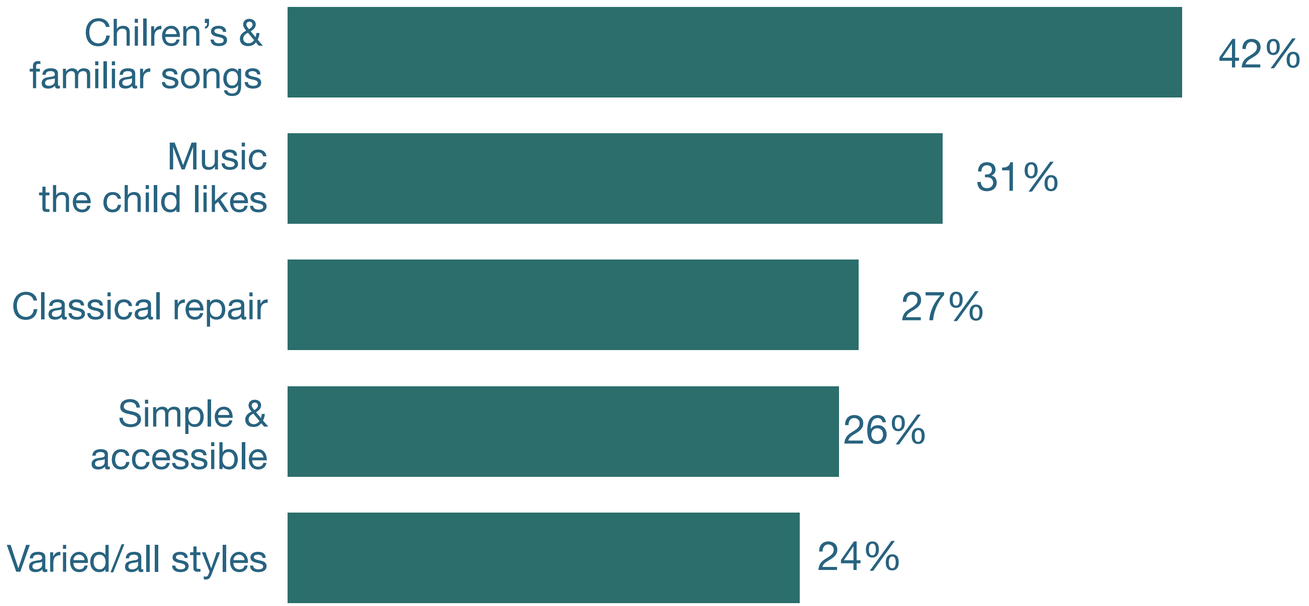
A clear order

Sound before symbol
Sing and feel the pulse first.

Play as vehicle:
Collaborative games

Notation & technique only
introduced when meaningful

What music should be used?



Chosen for the child, not the style

Familiar, singable songs
Simplicity, accessibility
and the child's own taste matter more than genre.

"*As varied as possible. Things that are familiar and things that are new.*" (245)

Note reading - Sound before sight!

Secondary at this age
Introduced after playing by ear

Postponed or gradual
For some until age 7; introduce slowly

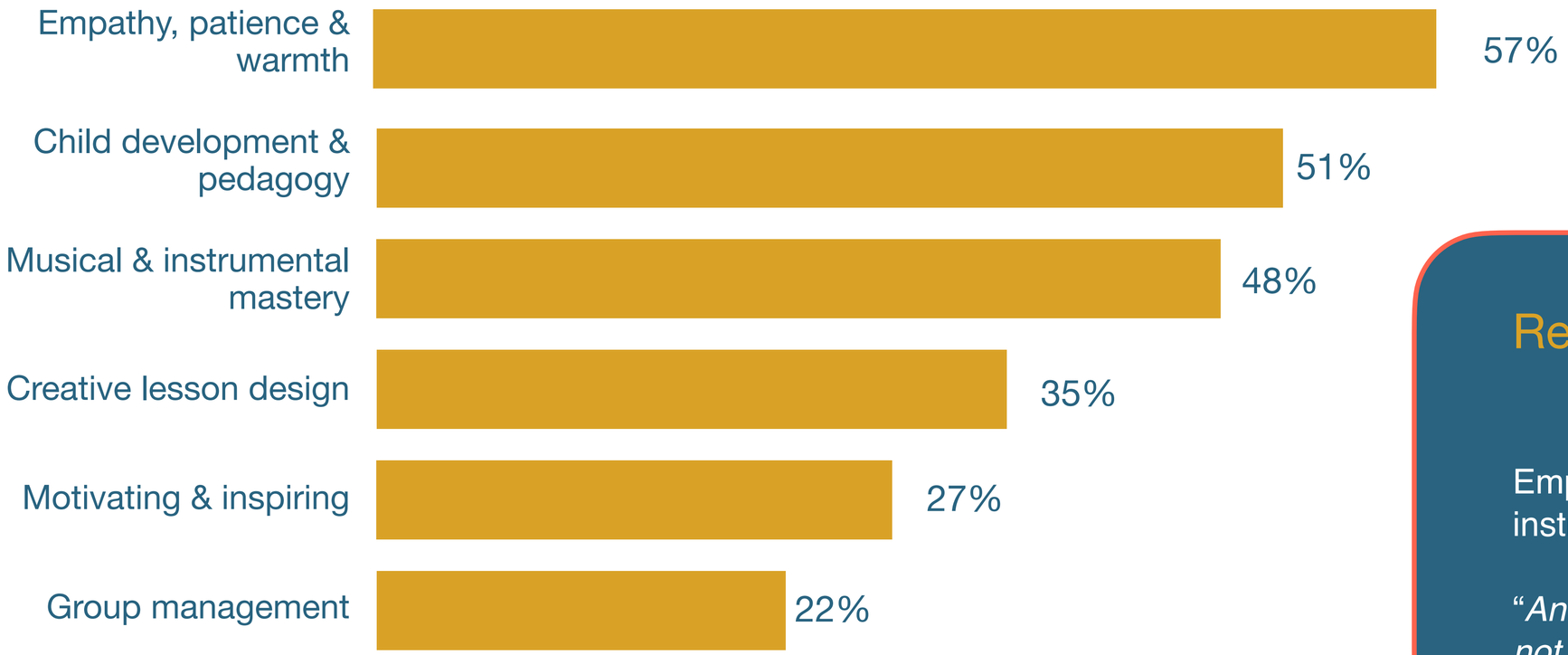
Connected to sound, never abstract
Singing!

< 1 in 10

Argued for an early, systematic start on notation

"I*t is better to be able to sing in tune and love music than to be able to read notes at the age of five.*"
(237)

THE COMPETENCIES TEACHERS SAY THE AGE DEMANDS



Relational before technical

Empathy and pedagogy outrank instrumental mastery

"*An early-childhood educator, not an instrument expert.*" (142)

A TENSION RUNNING THROUGH THE FINDINGS

Institutional “early start” logic

- Structured, instrument-centred lessons from a young age
- “The sooner, the better”
- •Mirrors the readiness / head-start framing of curricula & instruments

Child-centred reframing

- ECME matters more than early specialisation
- Enjoyment over discipline, sound before symbol, & play as vehicle
- Discipline is scaffolded; technique serves expression

Beliefs track the institution where teachers work,
not the instrument they play ➛ what the interpretative-framework lens predicts.

A TENSION RUNNING THROUGH THE FINDINGS

Design solves access not pedagogy

Child-friendly instruments resolve the one real consensus barrier: the physical. But teachers prize play, expression and sound-before-symbol, not a technical “head start.”

Common ground with existing methods

Teachers’ ethos echoes existing method’s
yet they resist repertoire-first, teacher-centred drill.

Consensual

Beliefs are strikingly shared.

Beliefs are shaped by institutional logic

A CHILD-CENTRED CONSENSUS, IN SEARCH OF A FRAMEWORK

In conclusion

- Teachers share a child-centred view: enjoyment and whole-child growth over a technical head start.
- The real belief is “the earlier the **music**, the better”, not early specialisation
- Physical suitability is the main genuine constraint — now largely met by child-sized instruments.
- Background rarely predicts beliefs; teaching context does.

Teacher education Train specialist pedagogues for 5–7; foreground play-based, sound-before-symbol practice.

A pedagogical framework Build it around the consensus — enjoyment, aural & embodied foundations, making music together, own pace.

Instrument design Reframe from “head start / step up” toward expressive, playful music-making.

Research agenda Fill the near-empty evidence base — outcomes for iECME and the three methods.

Thank you!



looking forward to your questions, remarks, ...

Slides

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